Helping students identify main ideas in subject readings

Practical guidance for subject lecturers - D04-S1–S6

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Students may understand individual words and sentences but struggle to identify the overall argument or distinguish important points from examples. The following activities make your approach to reading in the subject more explicit.

1. Set a clear reading purpose

Before assigning a reading, explain what students should look for and how they will use it.
How to do it: Give one or two focused questions alongside the reading. Make clear whether students need an overview or a detailed understanding of particular sections.

Example — Business: Read the report to identify why the company's profit fell. Be ready to explain the main reason and give two pieces of supporting evidence. Use that purpose to guide the follow-up discussion.

2. Model how to identify a main idea

Show students how you decide what matters in a short extract.

How to do it:

1 Display a short paragraph from a course reading. Give students time to read it, then explain aloud how you identify its main idea and distinguish it from supporting information.
2 Mark the information differently: underline the sentence expressing the main idea, circle supporting evidence and label examples.

3 Explain that the main idea does not always appear in the first sentence. It may appear later or need to be inferred by connecting several sentences.

Worked example — Business

A retailer's sales revenue rose from £100,000 to £120,000 over one year. However, its operating costs increased from £70,000 to £100,000. These increases included higher spending on staffing, transport and rent. As a result, its profit fell from £30,000 to £20,000 despite the growth in revenue.

Teacher's explanation:

The first sentence tells us that revenue increased. But I need to read the whole paragraph before deciding whether that is the main idea.

"The word 'However' introduces a change: costs also increased. Revenue rose by £20,000, while costs rose by £30,000.

"The final sentence brings these details together: operating profit fell despite higher revenue. I'll underline this sentence because it expresses the paragraph's main idea.

"I'll circle the figures because they provide evidence. Staffing, transport and rent are examples of costs; I'll label them 'examples'.

"I would summarise the paragraph as: 'The retailer's operating profit fell because its costs increased by more than its revenue.'"

Possible summary: The retailer earned more revenue, but its profit fell because its costs grew by a larger amount.

3. Provide a short reading guide

Give students a small number of questions that direct attention to the text's central message.

How to do it: Choose three or four questions suited to the reading. For example:

Reading-guide question	What students record
What issue or question does the text address?	One sentence
What is the author's main argument, finding or recommendation?	One or two sentences
What are the most important supporting points?	Two or three brief notes

What evidence supports those points?	Relevant examples, data or page references

Adapt the questions to the text. A research article may report findings; a case study may present a problem without recommending a solution.

4. Explain how the type of text affects where to look

Show students how the structure of a text can help them locate important information.

How to do it: Use an actual course reading. Point out its sections and explain what you expect to find in each. Then check those expectations against the text.

Example — A scientific research article

> "The abstract gives us an overview. The introduction explains the research question. The results report what the researchers found. The discussion explains what they think those findings mean."

Ask students to compare the abstract with the discussion or conclusion. Check whether the fuller account includes limitations or qualifications that their summary needs to preserve.

5. Use section summaries to build overall understanding

Help students move from understanding separate sections to understanding the whole text.

How to do it:

1 Choose meaningful stopping points, such as the end of a substantial section. Ask students to write one sentence capturing each section's main point.
2 After reading, ask: "How do these points connect? What overall argument or explanation do they build?"
3 Students then write a short overall summary. Explain that this requires selecting and connecting ideas, rather than simply joining all their section summaries.

Example — Economics

A reading examines three explanations for rising prices. Students summarise each explanation, then identify which explanation the author considers most convincing and why.

6. Ask students to justify their interpretation

Check whether students can explain why an idea is central to the text.

How to do it: Ask students to compare their summaries in pairs. Each student identifies a passage that supports their interpretation. Discuss differences that affect meaning.

Alternatively, provide three possible summaries and ask students to choose the best one.

Example using the retailer extract

Possible summary	Teacher feedback
A. The retailer's revenue increased by £20,000.	Accurate, but captures only one supporting detail.
B. Profit fell because costs increased more than revenue.	Captures the main explanation and matches the evidence.
C. The retailer should reduce staffing to restore profit.	Makes a recommendation that the extract does not establish.

Ask:

"Which summary best captures the whole extract? What evidence supports your choice?"

Accept different wording where students preserve the central meaning and can support their interpretation.

Supporting guidance

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing and Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Teaching support*. Relevant section: "Reading".

University of California, Davis, Center for Educational Effectiveness. (n.d.). *Strategies to increase engagement while reading*. Relevant section: "Teaching Strategies"

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign, University Library. (2025, March 7). *How to read a scientific paper: Structure of an article*.

Subject examples and lecturer demonstrations were developed for this toolkit. The University of Illinois resource addresses scientific research articles specifically.